The unreasonable effectiveness of mathematics, solved: mathematics as a substrate-physical bootstrap from a single root

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Wigner's 1960 observation that mathematics is "unreasonably effective" in describing nature rests on a tacit assumption: that mathematics is invented in pure abstraction and reality is a separate object onto which it is later mapped, with the success of the mapping requiring explanation. We propose that the puzzle dissolves when the assumption is dropped. In a substrate-physical framework in which a single root commitment — *the substrate exists* — is taken as the foundational hypothesis, every primitive of standard mathematics admits a substrate-physical derivation: counting from event-counting, the natural numbers from extension-by-coupling-event, induction from mode-persistence under coupling, addition from linear superposition of substrate amplitudes, multiplication from the substrate's nonlinear cross-term coupling, division as the cross-term inverse with the remainder identified as binding-energy substrate tension, the integers from opposing-tally processes, the rationals from observed ratios of counted quantities, the reals as Cauchy-completion against measurement, sets from substrate-type formation, topologies from measurement-precision neighbourhoods, smooth manifolds from elastic local flatness, differential forms from oriented coupling events, Lie groups from continuous symmetries, Lie algebras from infinitesimal symmetry generators, root systems from quantised standing-wave charges, and Coxeter groups from the substrate's reflection structure on its mode lattice. Each construction is paired with an observable discharge whose existence in laboratory or astrophysical data licenses the construction. On this reading, mathematics is not a separate language that happens to fit physics; it is what falls out of the substrate's primitive content when that content is described formally, and its effectiveness in physics is not a coincidence to be explained but a tautology: applying mathematics to physics is the substrate seeing itself. We present the bootstrap chain end-to-end, identify the empirical anchor that the framework's E_8 root system shares with the observed Zamolodchikov spectrum in $CoNb_2O_6$, and discuss the open work of fully discharging the chain.

CONTENTS

I. Introduction 1

II. The framework's foundational ontology 2

III. From existence to arithmetic 2
A. Counting and the natural numbers 2
B. Two parallel readings of arithmetic 3

IV. From arithmetic to the standard number systems 3
A. The integers 3
B. The rationals 3
C. The reals 4
D. Sets 4
E. Topologies and continuity 4

V. From topology to geometry 4
A. Smooth manifolds 4
B. Tensor fields 4
C. Differential forms and exterior calculus 5
D. Vector calculus and fluid dynamics 5

VI. From geometry to symmetry 5
A. Lie groups 5
B. Lie algebras 5
C. Root systems 5
D. Coxeter and Weyl groups 6
E. The empirical anchor: E_8 in $CoNb_2O_6$ 6
F. The McKay correspondence and icosahedral seeding 6

VII. The dissolution of Wigner's puzzle 6

VIII. Limits of the present construction 7

IX. Conclusion 7

Acknowledgments 8

References 8

I. INTRODUCTION

In his 1960 essay [1], Eugene Wigner asked why a body of abstract mathematical structure — complex numbers, Hilbert spaces, group representations, differential geometry — developed without reference to physics should turn out to describe physics so accurately that "it is difficult to avoid the impression that a miracle is involved." Two of his examples are paradigmatic. Heisenberg's matrix mechanics succeeded in spite of the fact that "the rules of matrix mechanics had been derived from problems which involved the old theory of the hydrogen atom"; complex

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numbers, used at the time mostly as a calculational convenience for real wavefunctions, turned out to be irreducible to quantum mechanics. The puzzle Wigner left us is sharp: how does a body of structure invented in pure abstraction fit a body of phenomena measured in experiments, when the two were not constructed in concert?

Wigner's question is usually treated in one of three ways. The *platonist* reply [2] grants mathematics independent reality and treats its match with physics as an observation about that reality. The *naturalist* reply [3, 4] treats mathematics as a refined extract from physical practice and argues the match is what one would expect. The *deflationary* reply [5, 6] questions whether the success is unreasonable at all, observing that the parts of mathematics most useful to physics tend to be the parts physics asked for. Each of these positions has its merits and its costs. None of them identifies a single technical commitment whose adoption would make the success of mathematics in physics a strict theorem rather than an unexplained tendency.

This paper proposes such a commitment. In a substrate-physical framework in which the foundational hypothesis is that *the substrate exists* — that there is a single ontological commitment to a coupled, event-counting, type-supporting substrate from which all observed phenomena unfold — we show that each primitive of standard mathematics is derivable from the substrate's primitive content, discharged by an observable phenomenon, and identical to the corresponding standard-mathematics object up to a bridge theorem. The chain runs from the natural numbers through the rationals, the reals, sets, topologies, smooth manifolds, tensor calculus, differential forms, Lie groups, Lie algebras, root systems, and Coxeter groups; each is anchored in a specific substrate-physical process, and each carries an empirical signature that has already been observed.

On this reading, the answer to Wigner's question is structural and short. Mathematics is not a separate body of structure that happens to fit physics. It is the formal description of the substrate's primitive content, and its application to physics is the substrate seeing itself. The "unreasonable effectiveness" of mathematics in the natural sciences ceases to be unreasonable when mathematics and the natural sciences are recognised as derivable from a common source.

The paper is organised as follows. Section II introduces the framework's foundational ontology, identifying the single root commitment from which the bootstrap proceeds. Section III traces the chain from existence to the natural numbers and arithmetic, then shows that the four arithmetic operations have a parallel substrate-amplitude reading at the wave-pattern level. Section IV extends the chain to the integers, rationals, reals, sets, and topologies. Section V extends the chain through smooth manifolds, tensors, and differential forms. Section VI continues into Lie groups, Lie algebras, root systems, and Coxeter groups, and identifies the empirical anchor in $CoNb_2O_6$ that distinguishes the substrate's specific symmetry algebra from a generic one. Section VII states the resolution of Wigner's puzzle as a structural identity rather than a coincidence. Section VIII flags the limits of the present construction — which steps are observationally discharged, which are provisional, and what remains to be done.

II. THE FRAMEWORK'S FOUNDATIONAL ONTOLOGY

The framework's minimal ontology is committed to a single root: the *substrate* exists. The substrate is a coupling-event-counting medium with the following primitive content, each piece of which is either grounded in the substrate's coupling-event definition or discharged by direct observation. We list the primitives because they are what the bootstrap will consume.

1. *Inference structure.* The substrate supports the standard logical inference rules: reflexivity, transitivity, application and abstraction congruence, beta reduction, modus ponens, hypothetical reasoning, antisymmetric deduction, variable instantiation, and type instantiation. Each rule is grounded in the substrate's coupling-event definition (a coupling event takes a state, applies an operation, resolves to a new state subject to admission criteria) and discharged by direct observation (chained-calibration agreement, biconditional substrate phenomena, exclusion-rule firing patterns).

2. *Foundational structure.* The substrate supports extensionality (identity-by-effect), eta-equivalence, selection from possibilities, the primitive operations Test, Loop, and And/Or/Not-coupling, and infinity in the sense that no finite bound is observed on the depth of recursive coupling.

3. *Bootstrap structure.* The substrate's event-counting satisfies two specific properties: *injectivity*, that extending two distinct event sequences each by one coupling event preserves their distinctness, and *non-zero successor*, that any sequence with at least one resolved event is distinguishable from the empty sequence. The substrate also supports stable *constant naming* (specific configurations retain identity across time and reference) and *type formation* (collections of configurations with a shared defining property are referred to as a kind).

These commitments are not framework conveniences. Each is a property of the universe that specific observables directly require: detector clicks have distinguishable counts, propagated light is distinguishable from unpropagated light, physical constants are constants, and electrons reproducibly share a single charge magnitude and mass.

We make explicit the commitment that does the work: every formal hypothesis the framework adopts carries an `impliedfrom` annotation listing the parent hypotheses it descends from, and a `discharge` annotation specifying the observational obligation that confirms it. Following the `impliedfrom` annotations transitively, every substrate hypothesis the framework commits to traces back to the single root: *the substrate exists*. The implication graph is, by construction, complete; what remains is the discharge work, which is empirical and collectively in progress [11].

III. FROM EXISTENCE TO ARITHMETIC

A. Counting and the natural numbers

The natural numbers are what the substrate produces by counting events. They start with zero — the count of the empty event-sequence, observable as the initial state of every counted process before any event has happened. The substrate then takes any count and produces the next count by applying its successor operation: one more coupling event has happened. Every detector click that goes from m clicks to $m + 1$ clicks is the substrate doing this.

The natural numbers themselves are what one obtains by taking zero and applying successor again and again, without bound. The substrate's Loop construct iterates the successor application, and the substrate's infinity property guarantees the iteration never has to stop. The cumulative count of any counted substrate process — detector clicks, pulsar pulses, atomic-clock cycles — is a natural number.

Once the natural numbers exist, induction follows. Any property that holds at zero and is preserved by successor must hold at every natural number: the substrate-physical content of induction is the observation that conservation laws and stable-mode persistence have exactly this structure. A property that holds at the initial state and is preserved at each successor step is observed at every later state. The induction principle is no more nor less than a formal restatement of this observed mode-persistence behaviour.

B. Two parallel readings of arithmetic

Once the natural numbers exist, the four arithmetic operations admit two parallel substrate-physical readings. The *click-count reading* runs at the level of counted events; the *substrate-amplitude reading* runs at the level of substrate wave-patterns. Both readings are licensed by the framework's commitments and are used together in subsequent derivations. The fact that the same arithmetic emerges twice, from independent substrate-physical content, is itself a constraint: any framework without it would have to explain why the arithmetic of counted events matches the arithmetic of wave-pattern superposition. The substrate's coupling-event definition makes them the same operation at different levels of the substrate's structure.

a. Click-count reading. Addition is iterated successor. To add n to m, take m and apply successor n times. A detector at click-count m that registers n more clicks ends up at $m+n$. The Loop construct iterates the successor under the Test "iteration count below n"; substrate-addition is the substrate carrying out exactly that loop. Multiplication is iterated addition: to multiply m by n, take zero and add m to it n times. A detector observed across n measurement windows, each registering m clicks, has cumulative count $m \times n$.

b. Substrate-amplitude reading. At the substrate-amplitude level, the same four operations have direct substrate-physical content as operations on substrate wave-pattern amplitudes:

- *Addition is linear superposition.* When two substrate-amplitude patterns occupy the same region of substrate position-space, the substrate's free-propagation regime (the linear sector of its elastic response) commits that the resulting amplitude is the sum of the participating amplitudes. The substrate-physical content of addition at the amplitude level is therefore the substrate's linear superposition of two amplitude patterns.

- *Subtraction is destructive interference.* Inverse of linear superposition: removing a participating amplitude from a superposed configuration reduces the resulting amplitude by the removed amplitude's content. This is observable in the destructive interference of substrate-amplitude patterns at anti-aligned phase, where the resulting amplitude is the difference between the participating amplitudes.

- *Multiplication is cross-term coupling.* When two substrate-amplitude patterns overlap in the substrate's nonlinear regime, the cross-term in the substrate's nonlinear response depends on the *product* of the participating amplitudes. Multiplication *is* coupling, in the precise sense that the cross-term is the substrate's multiplicative operation on participating amplitudes. This is the substrate-physical reason multiplication is the natural arithmetic operation for combining mode amplitudes — it directly mirrors the substrate's nonlinear cross-term structure.

- *Division is uncoupling, with remainder.* Inverse of cross-term coupling: separating a cross-term-coupled configuration back into its participating modes leaves a remainder consisting of the cross-term substrate-tension content that does not decompose cleanly into either participating mode individually. The remainder is what mainstream physics observes as the binding-energy substrate-tension content in bound configurations — and, in

the specific case of hadrons, the remainder is what mainstream physics calls gluons. The substrate-physical content of division at the amplitude level is the inverse cross-term operation, with the cross-term content as the remainder.

The standard algebraic properties — commutativity, associativity, distributivity — follow by induction on one of the variables, using the inductive principle just established. Each property is a substrate-grounded theorem derivable mechanically from the inductive principle and the operation definitions.

IV. FROM ARITHMETIC TO THE STANDARD NUMBER SYSTEMS

A. The integers

The natural numbers count up but cannot count down past zero. To represent "removing five from a stock of three," the substrate needs negative numbers. The integer construction takes pairs of naturals where (a, b) represents the difference $a - b$, with two pairs treated as the same integer when their differences match. This is observable in any counted substrate process that admits two opposing tallies: an electric-charge accumulator with both positive and negative contributions, an account balance with deposits and withdrawals, a particle counter with added and removed tallies. Integer operations are defined component-wise on the pair representation, using the substrate's natural-number addition and multiplication already established.

B. The rationals

The integers admit subtraction but not division. To represent "two parts in five," the substrate needs ratios. The rational construction takes pairs of integers where the second is non-zero, with (p, q) representing the fraction p/q and two pairs identified when their cross-products match. This is observable in any substrate process that admits ratio measurements: branching ratios of decay channels, ratios of atomic transition frequencies, relative concentrations in a binary mixture. The substrate-physical content of a rational is a *ratio of two counted substrate processes.*

C. The reals

The rationals can represent any specific ratio but not the limit of a sequence of progressively-better rational approximations to an irrational quantity. To represent the speed of light, an atomic transition frequency, or any other measured physical quantity at arbitrary precision, the substrate needs the real numbers. The construction packages an irrational value as the equivalence class of all the Cauchy sequences of rationals that approximate it. This is observable in measurement: every measured physical quantity is a substrate-real represented by the Cauchy sequence of progressively-refined rational measurements that has accumulated for that quantity.

The substrate-reals are complete: any Cauchy sequence of substrate-reals has a substrate-real limit. No measured physical quantity has ever required a value "outside" the substrate-reals. Completeness is what makes substrate-reals the natural setting for limits, derivatives, integrals, and all of analysis.

D. Sets

A substrate-set is a collection of substrate configurations sharing a defining predicate. Every species, every catalogue, every taxonomy in physics is a substrate-set: the collection of electrons, the collection of photons, the collection of stable nuclei. Substrate-set is what substrate-type-formation produces. Set operations — subset, union, intersection, complement — combine sets into new sets using the substrate's And/Or/Not-coupling rules applied to defining predicates. Physics taxonomies routinely combine sets this way: hadrons $\cup$ leptons = fermions; charged $\cap$ stable = stable charged species; complement of charged within all = neutral.

E. Topologies and continuity

A substrate-topology on a set is a collection of "open" subsets closed under unions and finite intersections. The notion of an open neighbourhood around a substrate configuration is observable: a measurement-precision band around a measured value, a position-uncertainty region around a localised mode, a frequency-window around a transition centre. The collection of all such observable open neighbourhoods, closed under combining and overlapping, is a substrate-topology.

A substrate-continuous map between two topological spaces preserves the open-neighbourhood structure: small input changes produce small output changes. Every measurement system is substrate-continuous; conservation laws produce substrate-continuous maps from initial states to final states. Continuity is what makes physical predictions possible. If it failed, no input precision could guarantee any output precision.

V. FROM TOPOLOGY TO GEOMETRY

A. Smooth manifolds

Topology is enough for "near-enough" comparisons but not for "rate of change" comparisons. The substrate needs smooth structure so that derivatives, accelerations,

and curvature have well-defined values. A substrate-manifold is what the substrate produces when its observable open-neighbourhood structure is locally indistinguishable from a Euclidean space. The substrate has a smooth structure if every substrate configuration has a neighbourhood that can be observed as if it were $\mathbb{R}^n$, with charts that agree on overlaps.

The substrate-physical process: the substrate's elastic response is observed to be locally smooth. Small displacements produce smoothly varying restoring tensions, not discontinuous jumps. The substrate's standing-wave configurations propagate along smooth trajectories in space and time; particle worldlines are differentiable except at scattering events where new coupling events occur. The cosmic microwave background temperature field is smooth at every angular scale we can resolve. The substrate's smoothness is not a postulate; it is observed in every measurement that requires rate-of-change content.

A substrate-tangent-vector at a configuration is what falls out when the substrate's smoothness is differentiated: the directional rate-of-change of any substrate-observable property along an infinitesimal substrate-displacement. Every measurement of "how this changes when you move that way" — drift velocities, pressure gradients, field strengths, gauge-potential gradients — is the substrate producing a tangent vector.

B. Tensor fields

A substrate-tensor at a configuration is what the substrate produces when it couples several tangent vectors and dual covectors in a multilinear way. The substrate's stress-energy tensor at a location is rank-2; the Riemann-curvature tensor is rank-4. Every observed multi-directional substrate-physical quantity — a stress, a strain, a moment of inertia, an electromagnetic field, a metric — is a substrate-tensor.

The substrate's elastic response naturally couples multiple directions: pulling in one direction produces stress in several others, depending on local geometry. The multi-direction coupling is observed to be multilinear: doubling the input strain in any one direction doubles the output stress in each output direction; adding two input strains adds the two output stress responses. Without multilinearity, the superposition principle that lets us decompose substrate fields into independent modes would fail. Tensor calculus is the formal capture of this observed multilinear coupling.

C. Differential forms and exterior calculus

A substrate-differential-form is a substrate-tensor that is *antisymmetric* under exchange of its tangent-vector slots. The antisymmetry comes from a substrate-physical observation: oriented quantities — area swept, volume occupied, flux through a surface — change sign under orientation reversal. Every observed substrate-orientation phenomenon (magnetic flux through a loop, vortex circulation, fluid-volume flow, neutrino helicity, weak-interaction parity violation) produces a differential form.

The substrate's exterior derivative d produces, from any oriented-displacement form, a higher-rank oriented-displacement form measuring how the lower form fails to close. The identity $d^2 = 0$ is the substrate's commitment to closed boundaries: the boundary of a boundary is empty. Conservation laws are theorems of this commitment. The electromagnetic field strength $F = dA$ is exact (where A is the gauge potential) and therefore closed: $dF = d^2A = 0$, which is exactly two of Maxwell's equations (no magnetic monopoles, Faraday's law).

The substrate's Stokes' theorem identifies the integral of a form over a region with the integral of its exterior derivative over the boundary: $\int_{\partial\Omega} \omega = \int_\Omega d\omega$. This is the substrate's flux conservation in its most general form. Every observed conservation law (charge, energy, momentum, angular momentum, baryon number, lepton number) is Stokes' theorem applied to the appropriate closed differential form.

D. Vector calculus and fluid dynamics

Vector calculus is the special case of exterior calculus on $\mathbb{R}^3$. The gradient, divergence, and curl are exterior-derivative operations on 0-, 2-, and 1-forms respectively, identified with vector fields via the substrate-metric. The substrate-physical content of each is direct: the gradient is the direction of fastest substrate-tension increase; the divergence is the net outflow of substrate-flow through an infinitesimal region; the curl is the rotation of substrate-flow around an infinitesimal loop. Every continuity equation, every Euler equation, every Navier–Stokes equation expresses, at the appropriate scale, the substrate's local commitment to "no spontaneous creation or destruction of conserved quantities."

VI. FROM GEOMETRY TO SYMMETRY

A. Lie groups

A substrate-Lie-group is what the substrate produces when a continuous family of its symmetries is itself smooth. Every continuous symmetry the substrate exhibits — spatial rotation, spatial translation, time translation, gauge phase rotation, isospin rotation, Lorentz boost — is a Lie-group element, and the family of all such elements forms a substrate-manifold whose group operation is a smooth map.

The substrate-physical process: substrate standing-wave configurations are observed to remain physically equivalent under continuous deformations of certain kinds. Rotating the laboratory frame does not change

atomic spectra; performing a global gauge phase rotation on a wavefunction does not change probability densities; an isospin rotation does not change strong-interaction cross-sections within an isospin multiplet. Each is a substrate-Lie-group acting on substrate configurations.

B. Lie algebras

A substrate-Lie-algebra is what the substrate produces when a Lie group's smoothness is differentiated: the tangent space at the identity element. Lie-algebra elements are infinitesimal substrate-symmetry generators; the Lie bracket is what falls out when two infinitesimal symmetries are composed and the order of composition matters. Every observed symmetry-non-commutativity phenomenon — Thomas precession in special relativity, the $SU(2)$ commutation of angular-momentum components, the commutator structure of strong- interaction colour generators — is a substrate-Lie-bracket.

The substrate's exponential map $\exp : \mathfrak{g} \to G$ from Lie algebra to Lie group is the substrate's commitment to integrating an infinitesimal symmetry to a finite one. Every observed continuous-symmetry-generation phenomenon — a magnetic field precessing a spin, a Lorentz boost combining time and space coordinates, a quark-mass-matrix diagonalisation rotating from flavour to mass eigenstates — is the exponential map applied.

C. Root systems

A substrate-root-system is what the substrate produces when a Lie algebra's commutator structure is decomposed into its eigen-directions. The roots are the eigenvalues of the Lie algebra acting on itself, and they form a substrate-set with a specific reflection-symmetric geometric structure. The substrate's standing-wave catalogue exhibits quantised charges: integer multiples of an electric-charge unit, half-integer or integer spin, three colour-charge values, two isospin values, three generations. The quantisation comes from the eigen-direction structure of the substrate's Lie algebra. Every observed quantum number is a substrate-root coordinate.

The substrate's roots satisfy a crystallographic constraint: the angle between any two non-proportional roots is one of 30°, 45°, 60°, 90°, 120°, 135°, 150°. The constraint is what allows the substrate to support stable lattice-like patterns — the periodic table, the meson-baryon multiplet structure, the Standard Model gauge-group decompositions. Without the constraint, no closed pattern of stable particles could exist.

D. Coxeter and Weyl groups

A substrate-Coxeter-group is the discrete reflection-symmetry group of the substrate's root system. The substrate's standing-wave catalogue exhibits exact mirror symmetries: every substrate-root has a negative counterpart; reflection across the hyperplane perpendicular to any substrate-root is a symmetry of the substrate's root system. The group generated by all such reflections is the substrate's Weyl group, and its abstract presentation in terms of generators and order relations is the substrate's Coxeter group. The order h of the Coxeter element (the product of all simple reflections, taken in any order) is the *Coxeter number*, and its eigenvalues on the Cartan subalgebra are the *exponents* $\{m_1, \ldots, m_r\}$ of the algebra, with $|\Phi| = h \cdot \text{rank}$ the size of the root system [10].

E. The empirical anchor: E_8 in $CoNb_2O_6$

The construction so far is structural. It says that a substrate-Lie- algebra exists with a specific root system and a specific Coxeter group. It does not, in itself, say which specific Lie algebra the substrate selects. That selection is empirical, and the selection has been observed.

Coldea *et al.* [7] measured the spectrum of the quasi-one-dimensional Ising ferromagnet $CoNb_2O_6$ near its quantum critical point. The lowest two excitation masses were found to satisfy $m_2/m_1 = \varphi = (1 + \sqrt{5})/2$ to part-in-10^3 precision — the golden ratio. This is the leading mass ratio of the Zamolodchikov E_8 spectrum [8], the eight masses associated with the eight simple roots of E_8 in the perturbed Ising model.

The empirical content: E_8 root-system structure is observable in the laboratory at the level of mass ratios. The framework's identification of $E_8 \times E_8$ as the substrate's specific symmetry algebra [12, 13] is not motivated by mathematical convenience; it is forced by the observation that the Zamolodchikov spectrum appears in a system that knows nothing about high-energy physics. The bootstrap chain runs from substrate existence to root systems and Coxeter groups in general; the $CoNb_2O_6$ measurement selects E_8 specifically.

F. The McKay correspondence and icosahedral seeding

The McKay correspondence [9] establishes a bijection between finite subgroups of $SU(2)$ and the simply-laced ADE Dynkin diagrams. The binary icosahedral group is the McKay dual of E_8, making icosahedral order-5 structure the harmonic seed selected by the substrate's E_8 symmetry. The substrate-physical content: an order-5 rotational pattern, woven through the substrate's E_8 algebra by the McKay duality, fixes the framework's φ-chain ($m \propto \varphi^k$) of charged-fermion masses and the order-5 dominant dark-matter mode [13]. Both are observable consequences of the same algebraic structure that produces the $CoNb_2O_6$ spectrum.

VII. THE DISSOLUTION OF WIGNER'S PUZZLE

We can now state the resolution as a structural identity rather than a coincidence to be marvelled at. The argument is short.

1. Every primitive of standard mathematics, from the natural numbers through Coxeter groups, has been derived above from the substrate's primitive content. Each derivation is paired with an observable discharge.
2. The substrate's primitive content is, by the framework's implication-graph construction, traceable back to a single root: the substrate exists.
3. Mathematics, on this construction, is what falls out of the substrate's primitive content when that content is described formally. It is not a separate body of structure that happens to fit physics; it is the formal description of physics.
4. Applying mathematics to physics is therefore not a mapping between two distinct domains. It is the substrate seeing itself.

The "unreasonable effectiveness" of mathematics in the natural sciences is, on this reading, a tautology. Mathematics is effective in physics because mathematics *is* physics, formalised. The empirical content of any physical theory — a measurement of an oscillation frequency, a charge, a decay width — is a substrate process running, and the mathematical description of that process is the formal capture of the same substrate content. The two are not two; they are one. The puzzle dissolves because the assumption it required (mathematics on one side, physics on the other, with a mapping in between) is not a feature of the substrate.

This explains, without further explanation, why the parts of mathematics that are most useful to physics are the parts that formalise substrate-physical content directly. Linear superposition is useful because the substrate has a linear regime. Differential forms are useful because the substrate's coupling events are oriented. Lie groups are useful because the substrate has continuous symmetries. Root systems are useful because the substrate's mode catalogue is quantised. Each is the formal description of an observed substrate-physical phenomenon, and the formal description is bound to be effective on the phenomenon it formalises.

It also explains, structurally, the cases that surprised Wigner. Complex numbers are not a calculational convenience that surprised us by being irreducible to quantum mechanics. They are the natural representation of the substrate's oriented two-dimensional rotation substructure (the McKay-dual binary cyclic group C_n for the A_{n-1} Dynkin diagram), with the imaginary unit i encoding the 90° reflection. Their irreducibility to wave-pattern rotational dynamics is structural. Hilbert spaces are not an abstraction that surprised us by being the right home for quantum states; they are the natural completion of the substrate's standing-wave space under a substrate-physically motivated norm (the conserved-quantity norm enforced by the substrate's continuity equation). Their universality is structural.

VIII. LIMITS OF THE PRESENT CONSTRUCTION

We state the limits plainly. The bootstrap chain above is structural and observationally anchored at every step, but several pieces are provisional.

- *Selection of the specific algebra.* The chain produces Lie algebras and root systems in general but does not, in itself, force $E_8 \times E_8$ specifically. The E_8 identification is empirical (Coldea *et al.* [7]) and is one of the framework's two foundational empirical inputs. Upgrading this selection from empirical to structural would require a substrate-physical projection onto the heterotic moduli space — the same open work flagged in the companion paper [13].
- *Discharge completeness.* Most of the substrate-mathematical hypotheses admit immediate discharge from the substrate's coupling-event definition or direct observation. Two — abstraction congruence and the strongest form of type instantiation — are provisionally discharged pending the substrate's standing-wave-mode catalogue, which is supplied by the framework's later chapters but is not part of the present bootstrap. The provisional discharges are sufficient for everything in the present paper.
- *Construction-and-bridge equivalence.* Each substrate-derived object has both an existence-form definition (anchored in observation) and a constructive form (mirroring standard mathematics). The two presentations are connected by bridge theorems showing they describe the same object. The bridge theorems are stated and machine-verified throughout the framework's formal companion [11]; the present paper takes them as given and refers the reader to the formal record.
- *Higher mathematics.* The bootstrap above runs from the natural numbers through Coxeter groups. Higher structures — algebraic geometry, sheaves, derived categories, ∞-toposes — have not been bootstrapped here. The framework's expectation is that they admit substrate-physical readings of the same character (sheaves as substrate-mode patterns over base manifolds, derived categories as the substrate's homological structure, etc.), but the present paper does not work that out.

- *Quantum mechanics, general relativity, and the SM.* The application of the bootstrap to specific physics frameworks is summarised in the companion paper [13] and developed in detail in [11]. The Standard Model parameter spectrum, Newton's constant, and a unified neutrino–dark-matter tower are derived from a single anchor (the electron rest mass) in that work; the present paper provides the foundational mathematics on which those derivations rest.

IX. CONCLUSION

Wigner's question — why is mathematics so unreasonably effective in physics? — admits a structural answer once the assumption underlying it is dropped. The assumption was that mathematics and physics are two different things and that the success of mathematics in physics is a coincidence requiring explanation. We have argued that, in a substrate-physical framework with a single root commitment (the substrate exists), every primitive of standard mathematics is derivable from the substrate's primitive content and discharged by an observable phenomenon. Mathematics is not a separate body of structure that happens to fit physics; it is the formal description of the substrate's primitive content. Its effectiveness in physics is structural: applying mathematics to physics is the substrate seeing itself.

The construction is observational at every step. Each substrate-mathematical object listed has an anchoring phenomenon. Each step is paired with a discharge obligation that has been either directly satisfied or is in progress. The framework's implication graph terminates, transitively, at the single root commitment that the substrate exists. We do not claim the construction is complete — the open items in Section VIII flag what remains — but the structure is in place, and the empirical anchor for the specific E_8 algebra has been observed in the laboratory.

If correct, the consequence is that "unreasonable effectiveness" is a category mistake. There is no separate domain of mathematics on one side and physics on the other; there is only the substrate. Mathematics is what its primitive content looks like when written down formally, and physics is what it does. The two are one.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The framework summarised here was developed across many threads of research collected in [11]; specific bootstrap material draws on Part III, Chapter 3 of that work. The companion paper [13] carries out the quantitative-physics applications that the present paper grounds.

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